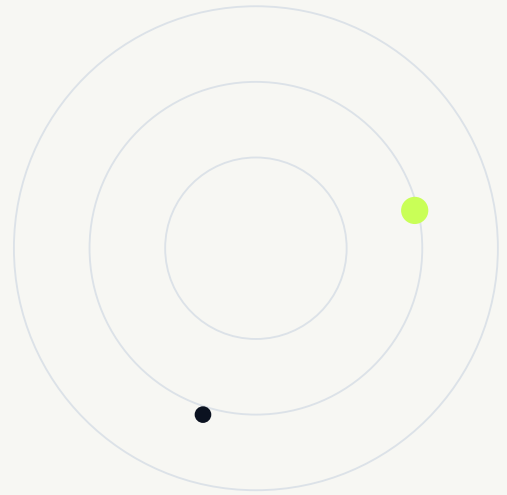




AI READY COLOMBO

Practical AI skills for a changing world.



STARTER GUIDE

**Use AI well.
Check what matters.
Keep your judgment.**

A practical reference for students, graduates and early-career professionals learning to use generative AI with more confidence and better judgment.

Prepared by Ravindu Nawanjana

AI Ready Colombo

Contents

Use this guide as a quick reference after the AI Ready Colombo learning journey. Read it from start to finish, or jump to the page you need.

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One thing to remember

Use more caution when the information is sensitive, the claim matters, or the consequences of an error are higher.

What generative AI is good at - and where it can go wrong

Generative AI can be genuinely useful. It can help you get started, organise ideas, explain something in another way, turn rough notes into a cleaner draft, or give you a first pass at a plan. The catch is simple: a useful answer can still be wrong.

Good uses

- Brainstorming when you are stuck.
- Drafting or improving writing you will review yourself.
- Explaining unfamiliar concepts in simpler language.
- Organising notes, tasks or research questions.
- Practising interviews, presentations or difficult conversations.
- Comparing options before you make a decision.

Where to slow down

- Statistics, dates, quotations and named research.
- Medical, legal, financial or other high-stakes information.
- Current events or anything that may have changed recently.
- Confidential work, university or personal information.
- Decisions where an error could affect someone else.

A confident answer is not the same as a correct answer.

Treat AI output like a draft from a fast assistant. Read it, question it and decide what deserves checking before you use it.

Get better results with CTCO

You do not need a complicated prompt formula. You just need enough information for the AI to understand what you want. CTCO is a simple way to do that.

Context What should the AI know about your situation?	Task What exactly do you want it to do?
Constraints What limits, rules or boundaries should it follow?	Output What should the final response look like?

A weak prompt

Help me prepare for an interview.

A stronger version

I am a final-year university student preparing for an entry-level marketing internship interview. Help me practise likely interview questions. Focus on questions suitable for someone with limited professional experience. Ask one question at a time and give me short feedback after each answer.

Blank CTCO template

Context	What should the AI know?
Task	What do I want it to do?
Constraints	What should it avoid or keep in mind?
Output	How should it respond?

Use AI on tasks that actually matter

AI becomes more useful when it is tied to a real task. The point is not to use it everywhere. Use it where it removes friction, gives you a useful first draft, or helps you think through a problem.

Studying Explain a difficult concept, turn your notes into practice questions, compare two theories, or build a revision plan.	Work Clean up an email, organise meeting notes, structure a brief, brainstorm campaign ideas, or prepare questions before a meeting.
Career Practise interview questions, improve a CV bullet, prepare questions for an employer, or identify skills to develop.	Projects Turn messy notes into actions, compare possible approaches, build a checklist, or identify what information is still missing.

Use AI where it reduces friction. Keep human judgment where the outcome matters.

A useful habit: ask one more question

The first answer is rarely the best answer. Before you copy anything into your work, ask a follow-up that forces the AI to check its own reasoning.

- What assumptions are you making?
- What might be wrong with this answer?
- What important context could be missing?
- Give me the strongest counterargument.
- What information would change your recommendation?

Inspect first. Verify what matters.

Some AI outputs are low-risk. If you are asking for presentation title ideas, you probably do not need to fact-check every option. Other outputs deserve more care.

Slow down when you see

- statistics, dates or percentages
- quotations
- research findings
- laws or regulations
- medical or financial claims
- named studies, reports or sources
- current information

Asking the same AI again is not independent verification.

Before trusting an important claim

- Can I confirm this with an independent source?
- Is that source reliable for this topic?
- Is the information current?
- Does the source actually support the claim?
- Am I reading the original source or another summary?

Watch for bias and missing context

An answer can sound reasonable and still be one-sided. This matters even more when the answer agrees with you. Try asking for the strongest opposing view or for evidence that would challenge the conclusion.

Think before you upload

A useful AI tool is still a place where you are sharing information. Before you paste in a document, screenshot or conversation, ask yourself what would happen if that information reached the wrong person.

Usually lower-risk

Public information, fictional examples, generic prompts and non-sensitive notes you are comfortable sharing.

Pause and check

Workplace documents, internal reports, client information, unpublished research, financial details, IDs, passwords and private conversations.

These controls may be separate

- Chat history
- Memory or personalisation
- Model improvement or training
- Feedback you choose to submit

Turning off one setting does not automatically turn off the others. Product settings also change, so check the current privacy controls of the tool you use.

If sharing it would create a problem, pause before uploading it.

For university or workplace information, your organisation's rules come first. A paid account or a request to 'not save this' does not automatically make confidential information safe to upload.

The AI Ready workflow

When the stakes are higher than a casual question, use a repeatable process instead of jumping straight from prompt to copy-paste.

DEFINE What are you actually trying to achieve?	PROMPT Give the AI enough context and clear instructions.	INSPECT Read the response. Look for gaps, assumptions and errors.	VERIFY Check important claims with reliable independent sources.	DECIDE Use your own judgment for the final call.
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DEFINE

What are you actually trying to achieve? What decision or outcome are you working toward?

PROMPT

Give enough context and clear instructions. Use CTCO when it helps.

INSPECT

Read the response. Look for weak assumptions, gaps, vague reasoning or overconfidence.

VERIFY

Check important claims independently. The higher the stakes, the more verification matters.

DECIDE

Use your own judgment for the final decision. AI can support your thinking. It should not automatically replace it.

Your quick checklist

You do not need to run through every question for every AI interaction. Use more caution when the information is sensitive, the claim is important, or the consequences are higher.

☐	Did I explain the task clearly?
☐	Did I give enough context?
☐	Does the response actually make sense?
☐	Are important claims verified?
☐	Did I share anything sensitive?
☐	Could relevant context be missing?
☐	Have I considered another perspective?
☐	Am I still making the final decision myself?

My own AI rules

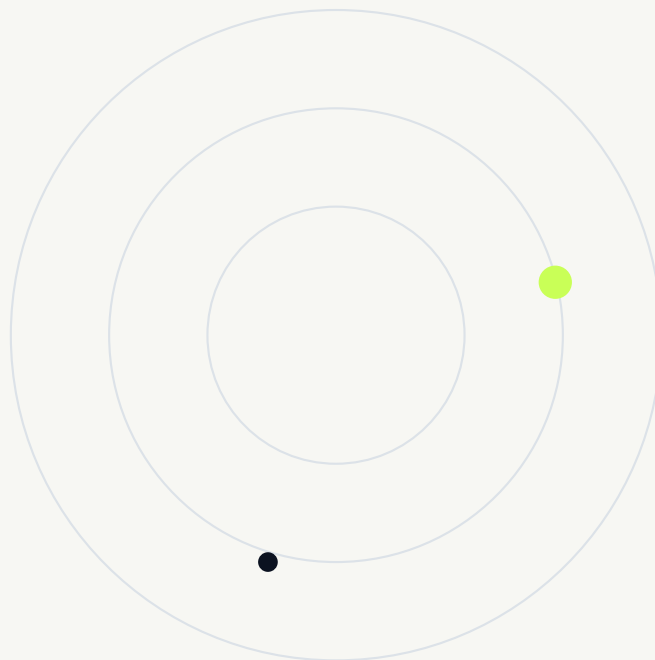
I will use AI for	_____
I will always verify	_____
I will never upload	_____
I will slow down when	_____
I will keep human judgment for	_____

Being AI-ready means knowing when AI helps, what needs checking, what data to protect, and when the final call should stay with you.

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**Define. Prompt. Inspect.
Verify. Decide.**

Keep the tool useful by keeping your judgment in the loop.